



THE LITERATIUM COMPANION · VOLUME I

A SLOW TRAVELLER'S GUIDE

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# *Mompox*

LA CASA DE LAS HISTORIAS



EDITION MMXXVI · HOTEL LITERATIUM

*Mompox does not exist,  
exactly. It is a rumour  
a traveller brings back  
from the river — a  
town the river forgot,  
and so the world has  
had to remember.*

— FROM A GUEST BOOK



MORNING MIST  
ON THE  
MAGDALENA,  
LOOKING  
SOUTH  
TOWARD THE  
PONTE SAN  
JUAN DE DIOS



A COURTYARD AT HOTEL LITERATIUM, SIX O'CLOCK  
LIGHT

## CHAPTER ONE

# Welcome

I

*A first evening, and the beginnings of orientation. What this book is, and what it is not.*

*"The traveller sees what he sees; the tourist sees what he has come to see."*

— G. K. CHESTERTON

There is a particular quality to an evening in Mompox. The heat of the day releases slowly. Bats fold through the air above the rooftops. From somewhere on Calle Real del Medio a bicycle bell sounds once, twice, and then does not sound again.

You have come a long way to be here. Six hours by road from Cartagena, a river crossing at Magangué, a final slow approach through pastures and water. Mompox does not announce itself. It simply appears, and after a moment you understand that the journey was the announcement.

The first mosquitoes come out at six. The hotel provides coils for the terrace.

This Companion is not a guidebook in the sense you may be accustomed to. It will not tell you the seven things you must see before lunch. It will not rank the churches. It assumes you have come to stay, to read, to walk slowly, to listen. It assumes you are willing, on at least one afternoon, to do nothing at all — and to consider that afternoon well spent.

What follows is a series of small introductions: to the river, which is the reason there is a town here at all; to the architecture, which has barely changed in three centuries; to the churches, which hold the silverwork of the colonial goldsmiths; to the filigree, the spider-web jewellery that is still made here by hand; to the food, which comes from the river and the garden and the slow-stirred pot; to the birds, who do not know they live in a UNESCO site.

It is, finally, a book about slowness. Mompox was forgotten for a hundred and fifty years because the river changed course. That forgetting preserved it. Now that the road has come, the forgetting will not last much longer. To visit now is to visit at a particular moment — between the long sleep and whatever comes next.



## *THREE HOURS, THREE NOTES*

### **MORNING · 5.30**

The first rooster, two streets away. Then, beneath it, the river — a low continuous breath that you stop hearing by the second day. A bicycle on the cobblestones. The gate of the hotel, opening.

### **EVENING · 6.45**

The church bell of Santa Bárbara, three slow strokes. A radio playing bolero somewhere across the patio. The fronds of the royal palm moving against each other — a dry paper sound. A child being called in for dinner.

### **RIVER · ALWAYS**

Stand on the malecón at the hour when the light goes pink. Listen below the human noise. The river makes a sound like cloth being drawn slowly across a floor. That is the sound Mompox has always heard.



A WHITEWASHED WALL ON CALLE DE LA  
ALBARRADA, LATE AFTERNOON

## CHAPTER TWO

# History

## II

*A town founded by men looking for gold, which found a river instead, and stayed for the trade.*

| *"Si a Caracas debo la vida, a Mompox debo la gloria."*

— SIMÓN BOLÍVAR

Mompox was founded on the third of May, 1537, by Alonso de Heredia — brother of Pedro de Heredia, the founder of Cartagena. He came looking for gold and a route to the interior. He found a low ridge between two arms of the Magdalena floodplain, occupied by a Malibú fishing village, and decided it would make a useful port.

For three centuries it was more than useful. Mompox sat on the only practical route between the Caribbean and the highlands of the interior: a river highway that carried European goods up to Bogotá and the gold, tobacco, and cacao of the interior down to Cartagena and from there to Spain. By 1777 the town was wealthy enough to mint its own coinage — the Quinta Real, the royal fifth — and the great houses of Calle Real del Medio were built to demonstrate it.

The wealth brought ideas. On the sixth of August, 1810, Mompox became the first town in the Viceroyalty of New Granada to declare absolute independence from Spain. Two of Bolívar's most important generals — Juan José Rondón and Hermógenes Maza — were momposinos. Bolívar himself passed through several times. The quote attributed to him — "If to Caracas I owe my life, to Mompox I owe my glory" — is still painted on the wall of the Casa del Ayuntamiento.

The decline was slow, and came from the river. In the middle of the nineteenth century the Magdalena began to shift its main channel toward the Loba branch, several kilometres to the east. The steamboats that had begun to ply the river in the 1820s could no longer reach Mompox's wharves. Trade moved to Magangué, the new railhead. By 1900 Mompox was a backwater. By 1950 it was nearly a ruin.

What saved it was precisely this neglect. There was no money to knock anything down. The colonial houses stayed standing, half-inhabited, slowly returning to the colour of earth. In 1995, UNESCO inscribed the Historic Centre of Santa Cruz de Mompox on the World Heritage List — citing criteria (iv) and (v): an outstanding example of a Spanish colonial river settlement, and a traditional human settlement representative of a culture which has become vulnerable under the impact of irreversible change.

The road from Cartagena arrived only in the 1970s. Before that, you came by river, or you did not come at all. Even now the road is single-lane in places, and the last thirty kilometres flood in the October rains. Mompox remains, in a real sense, an island.



## HISTORICAL TIMELINE

# Four hundred and eighty-nine years on the river

*The dates that shaped Mompox — a slow accumulation, then a long quiet, then a slow rediscovery.*



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Sources: UNESCO World Heritage List (ref. 742); Archivo General de la Nación, Colombia; chronicler accounts collated by the Casa de la Cultura de Mompox. Some dates remain in dispute among colonial historians; we have followed the consensus.





*"There are towns which exist so that time  
may have somewhere to deposit itself."*

— FROM A JOURNAL





THE MALECÓN AT DAWN, LOOKING EAST TOWARD  
THE LOBA BRANCH

### CHAPTER THREE

# The River

III

*The Magdalena made Mompox, and then it left. The town has spent a hundred and fifty years remembering.*

*"The river was everything. It was the road, the post, the newspaper, the police, and the calendar."*

— A BOATMAN

The Río Magdalena is fifteen hundred kilometres long. It rises in the páramo de las Papas, in the Colombian massif south of Bogotá, and runs north through the entire length of the country to the Caribbean at Bocas de Ceniza. For most of its course it is brown, slow, and broad. By the time it reaches Mompox it has already accepted the Cauca and is about to accept the San Jorge.

The bend at Mompox is one of the river's great loops. Here the Magdalena turns east, then north, then west again, enclosing the town on three sides in a horseshoe of water. The Spanish chose the site because the bend slowed the current and made docking easy. For three hundred years the malecón — the riverfront promenade — was the busiest wharf between the interior and the sea.

Then, in the middle of the nineteenth century, the river chose a different path. During a great flood it broke through to the Loba branch, several kilometres to the east, and the main channel followed. The wharves of Mompox were suddenly on a backwater. The steamboats — which had begun to ply the river only in the 1820s — moved to Magangué. The trade went with them. Mompox was left with its houses, its churches, and a river it could no longer reach.

It still cannot be reached, not in the old way. There is a small port where wooden canoes tie up, and where you can hire a boat to take you fishing in the ciénagas or across to the far bank. But the great commercial river is gone. What remains is a slower, older river — the river of fishermen, of egret, of the late afternoon when the heat comes off the water and walks through the town.

You should walk the malecón at sunset. The river is wide enough that you cannot see the far bank clearly. The water reflects the sky, which at that hour is pink and ochre. Egrets fly low to roost. Children dive from the steps. The whole town comes out, in that hour, to look at the river — as if it were still the main thing, which of course it is.

A fisherman sits on the malecón wall, mending a net with a wooden needle. He does not look up.



## *FIVE SCENTS TO LOOK FOR*

### **COFFEE · BEFORE DAWN**

The hotel's house bean, ground at 5.30, drifting through the courtyard. A citrus note over a darker caramel.

### **RAIN · ON WARM DUST**

In the wet season, the first drops on the dry road raise a sweet, mineral smell — petrichor, the geologists call it. In Mompox it is the smell of relief.

### **RIVER · AT EVENING**

A cool, vegetal smell — water weed, mud, fish. It comes off the water at the moment the heat breaks.

### **JASMINE · IN A DOORWAY**

Planted at the entrance of many houses. You will pass through a cloud of it on Calle de Atrás after dark.

### **FRESH BREAD · AT THE BAKERY ON CALLE DEL MEDIO**

Pandebono, pan de bono, pan de yuca — pulled from the oven at six. The smell crosses the street and finds you.



A WOODEN BALCONY ON CALLE REAL DEL MEDIO,  
WITH TURNED BALUSTERS

#### CHAPTER FOUR

# Architecture

## IV

*Andalusian in origin, Caribbean in adaptation, momposina in patience. A vocabulary of whitewash, tile, and shadow.*

*"The house is built around its patio, the patio around its tree, the tree around its shade."*

The architecture of Mompox is the architecture of patience. The walls are thick — sometimes a metre — built of brick and rough stone, then plastered and white-washed every year. The roofs are clay tile, laid on a frame of cedar and cañafistolo in the par y nudillo system: beams paired and notched, no nails, the whole structure interlocking like a sentence.

The plan is Andalusian. Rooms open onto an interior patio — sometimes two patios in sequence, the second one for the kitchen and the well. The patio is the heart of the house. A tree grows in it, usually a mango or a tamarind. The rooms breathe through the patio, and the patio breathes through the rooms.

The street facade is severe. Whitewashed wall, a single great door of cedar — sometimes six metres tall, with a smaller postigo cut into it for everyday use — and above, a wooden balcony with turned balusters. The balcony is where the household watches the world. From inside, you see only the street. From the balcony, you see everyone else's balcony, and the church at the end of the street, and the sky.

The window grilles — rejas — are wrought iron, brought from Cartagena in the colonial centuries because the salt air of the coast rusted them too quickly there. Mompox's distance from the sea preserved them. Many of these grilles are two hundred years old and show the maker's mark of the smith who forged them.

The cobblestones are uneven. After rain they are slippery. Watch your step on Calle de Atrás.

The town has three main streets, all parallel to the river: Calle de la Albarrada (the riverfront), Calle Real del Medio (the principal street), and Calle de Atrás (the back street). Three plazas — Concepción, San Francisco, Santa Bárbara — punctuate the length. There is no single central square, as there would be in most Spanish colonial towns. Mompox is a river town, not a plaza town. The river was the plaza.



## SIX SMALL THINGS TO NOTICE

01 **THE DOORS**

The cedar doors of the great houses are studded with bronze nails in geometric patterns. The nails are not decorative — they hold the cross-braces in place — but they have been arranged with care.

02 **THE BALCONIES**

Turned balusters, each one hand-carved on a lathe. No two are quite identical. The wood is cedar or amaranto, darkened with age.

03 **THE WINDOW BARS**

Wrought iron, sometimes painted dark green. Look for the smith's mark at the base — usually a small punch, two letters.

04 **THE TREES**

Mango, tamarind, guayacán. The guayacán blooms violet in May. The tamarind drops pods on the patio tiles in February.

05 **THE CORNICES**

A simple moulded plaster line where wall meets roof. Often the only ornament on a facade. The profile varies by century — eighteenth century is heavier, nineteenth more refined.

06 **THE CATS**

They belong to no one and to everyone. They sleep in doorways and on the warmer patches of tile. They have been here longer than anyone can remember.





CALLE REAL DEL MEDIO, SIX O'CLOCK  
EVENING LIGHT, LOOKING SOUTH TOWARD  
SANTA BÁRBARA





THE BELL TOWER OF SANTA BÁRBARA, AGAINST AN  
EVENING SKY

CHAPTER FIVE

# The Churches

V

*Six churches, three convents, one hospital. The silverwork of the colonial goldsmiths, still in situ.*

*"We built for God in stone, and for ourselves in mud. Time has reversed the matter."*

For a town of fewer than forty thousand people, Mompox has an improbable number of churches. There are six principal ones, three former convents, and a hospital chapel that has been in continuous operation since 1550 — making it, by some reckonings, the oldest functioning hospital in the Americas. The reason is the river. Mompox was rich, and riches in the colonial centuries were spent on God.

The Inmaculada Concepción, on the central plaza, serves as the cathedral. The original church was built in 1541; the present building dates from 1839. It is large, plain, and dignified — the interior is whitewashed, with a coffered ceiling of cedar and a single great painting of the Immaculate Conception above the high altar. The silver tabernacle, made in the Mompox mint, is one of the finest pieces of colonial silverwork in Colombia.

Santa Bárbara is the most photographed. Built in 1613, it has an octagonal baroque bell tower with a balcony — supposedly built so that the bell-ringer could also keep watch for pirates on the river. The facade is covered in plaster mouldings of flowers and fruit. Stand in the plaza at the hour the bells ring for vespers and you will understand why Mompox was a UNESCO site before any other town in Colombia.

San Agustín, the Basílica Menor since 2012, was the church of the Augustinian convent. Founded in 1606, it has a fine cloister and a library — partly dispersed, partly still in place — that was once one of the best in the Caribbean. San Francisco, founded in 1580, is the oldest standing church in Mompox; its polychrome wooden retablos are among the best-preserved in the country.

San Juan de Dios, the hospital chapel, has been in operation since 1550. Santo Domingo, near the cemetery, dates from about 1544. The cemetery itself, Cementerio Central, was built in 1830 and is worth a slow visit — the mausoleums of the great momposino families are arranged along avenues of palm, with a colony of cats in residence.

If you visit only one, make it Santa Bárbara, at six in the evening, when the light catches the tower. If you have time for two, walk to the Inmaculada Concepción afterward and look at the silver.



## IN AND AROUND THE CHURCHES

**01 THE MUSEO DE ARTE RELIGIOSO**

On the second floor of the Casa Bolivariana, around the corner from the Inmaculada Concepción. Three hundred and twenty pieces of colonial gold and silver, including a filigree monstrance that is among the finest in the Americas.

**02 THE FRESCOES OF THE CASA DE LA CULTURA**

An eighteenth-century house, formerly a school, with fragments of fresco on the patio walls — a secular cycle, unusual for the period, depicting the four seasons.

**03 THE WOODEN CONFESSIONAL OF SAN FRANCISCO**

Hand-carved cedar, signed and dated 1782. The joinery is so fine that the joints are invisible.

**04 THE BELL-RINGER'S HOUSE AT SANTA BÁRBARA**

Adjacent to the tower, with a covered passageway that allowed the bell-ringer to reach the tower in rain. The passageway is original.

**05 THE CATS OF THE CEMETERY**

A resident colony, fed by the keeper. The grave of "El Gato" — a much-loved tomcat — has its own small headstone.



A DOORWAY ON CALLE DE ATRÁS, SLIGHTLY AJAR,  
LATE AFTERNOON

## CHAPTER SIX

# Hidden Mompox

VI

*A town rewards those who walk without a destination. Some notes on what you might find.*

| "What is hidden is not secret; it is only waiting to be noticed."

— MARTICA, ON THE TERRACE

There is a Mompox that the visitor sees on the first day, and another that emerges on the third. The first is the one in the photographs: the malecón, the churches, the whitewashed balconies. The second is slower, smaller, and more particular. It is made of the things that do not announce themselves.

There are the donkey carts, still in daily use, carrying water or produce from the river road. The donkeys are grey and patient. They know the way home without being led.

There is the print shop — once the Imprenta de la Palestra, founded in 1883 — which still has its original presses. They are not always in operation, but if you knock, the keeper will sometimes show you the type cases. Each drawer holds a font. The compositor sets the type by hand, letter by letter, in the old way.

There are the closed doors. Mompox is full of houses whose ground floors have not been opened in decades. Behind them are courtyards, gardens, fountains, sometimes a small chapel. You will not see them. But if you are lucky, a door will be open for an hour — the family is cleaning, or preparing for a feast — and you will catch a glimpse. Mompox is a town of interiors. The street is the outside of an inside.

There is the Piedra de Bolívar — a stone in a small plaza near the river, where Bolívar is said to have sat and read. The stone is now surrounded by a low iron railing. There is no sign. You find it by being told.

And there is Café Ti, on a corner of the central plaza, where in the evenings a small jazz group plays — sometimes locals, sometimes a touring musician. The Festival Internacional de Jazz de Mompox, held each September, brings forty thousand visitors to a town of forty thousand. For the rest of the year, on most nights, you can find a single guitarist playing for tips.

The power goes out sometimes — usually for an hour, usually in the evening. The hotel has candles. The candles are better than the lights.



## *FOUR SMALL THINGS, BY THE HOST*

### **A BOAT TRIP AT FIVE IN THE MORNING**

Out to the mouth of the Ciénaga de Pijiño. The water is glass. The fishermen are setting their nets. You will not be a tourist on this trip; you will be a witness.

### **AN AFTERNOON AT THE TALLER ESCUELA DE FILIGRILLA**

Sit with one of the maestros for an hour. Watch how the wire is drawn. Buy nothing if you like; the conversation is the point.

### **A BOTTLE OF DULCE DE LIMÓN FROM DOÑA ADA**

A Mompox sweet, made by hand, sold from her house on Calle del Medio. Bring one home. It is the taste of the town.

### **A READING HOUR, ON THE HOTEL TERRACE, AFTER LUNCH**

Choose a book from the hotel library. Choose a chair in the shade. Do not check the time. This is not a recommendation; it is the entire point of coming.





*"A town is the sum of its closed doors."*





A MAESTRO'S HANDS AT THE WORKBENCH,  
DRAWING WIRE TO SPIDER-WEB FINENESS

CHAPTER SEVEN

# Filigree

VII

*A thread of gold or silver, drawn to the fineness of hair, knotted into a leaf, a bird, a moon. The craft Mompox has kept.*

| *"What we make here, no machine has ever made. No machine ever will."*

— A MAESTRO

Filigree — filigrana — is the art of working fine wire into delicate ornamental forms. The technique is old: it was practised in Mesopotamia three thousand years before Christ, and brought to the Americas by Andalusian goldsmiths in the sixteenth century. Mompox is, today, the only place in South America where it is still regularly practised as an industry.

The technique begins with a small ingot of pure silver or 18-carat gold. The ingot is hammered into a rod, then drawn — by hand, through a series of progressively smaller holes in a steel drawplate — into wire of diminishing thickness. The final wire is thinner than human hair. It must be handled with tweezers. A breath will bend it.

The wire is then shaped. Using tiny pliers and a charcoal block, the maestro curls it into spirals, loops, and figures-of-eight — the grains and threads that make up the design. These small units are assembled into larger units; the larger units into a finished piece. The join is made with a solder of finer alloy, applied with a minute flame. When the piece is finished, it is washed in acid and polished. What began as a solid ingot ends as something that weighs almost nothing and looks like lace.

The Escuela Taller de Mompox, founded in 1996 with Spanish government support, trains new maestros in the traditional technique. Before the school, the craft was dying — the old maestros were passing without apprentices. Today there are perhaps forty working filigree artists in Mompox, organised in small family workshops: the Tres Palacios, the Villanueva, the Pupo, the Rocha, the Herrera. Each has a signature. Each has a small showroom. All welcome visitors who come to look, not only to buy.

The pieces themselves are of a fineness that has to be seen to be understood. A pair of pendi-entes — earrings — may take three weeks to make. A small bird in gold, a centimetre long, may take a month. The craft is unmechanisable. The prices are not what you would expect, given the labour. Buy directly from the workshop if you can.

The maestro pauses, sets down his tweezers, drinks a tinto from a small enamel cup. Then he picks up the wire again.

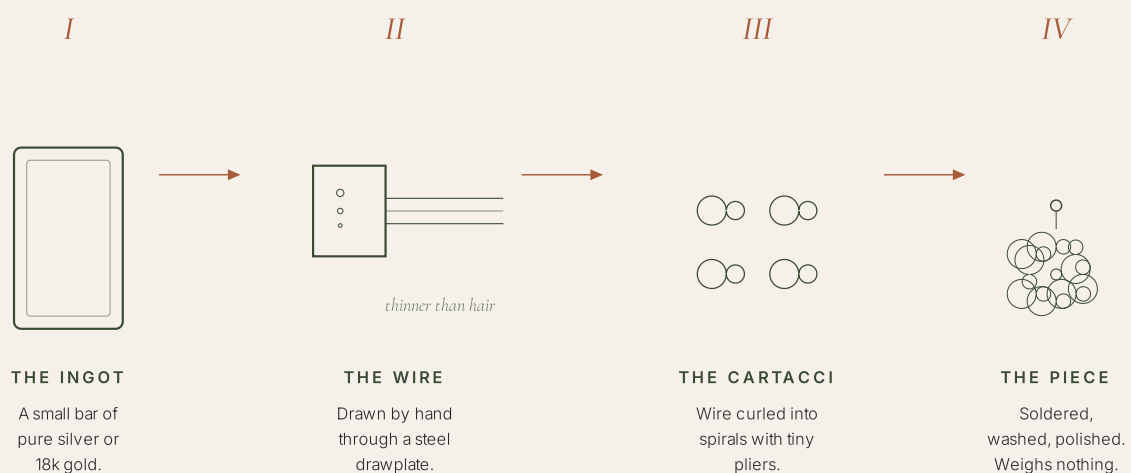


## A NOTE ON THE CARTACCI

The basic unit of Mompox filigree is the *cartaccio* — a tight spiral of wire, shaped like a small snail shell. The cartacci are joined side by side to form a sheet of "lace". The density of the spirals determines the weight and the price. A piece described as *filigrana completa* is made entirely of cartacci; *filigrana media* combines cartacci with flat sheet. Ask to see both. The difference is visible — and so is the difference in price.

# From ingot to lace

*The four stages by which a piece of solid metal becomes a piece you can pass through a keyhole.*



## NOTES

A finished piece may take three weeks (earrings) to a month (a small figure). The wire, at its thinnest, is around 0.1 mm. There are no machines in a Mompox filigree workshop. There are only hands, tweezers, pliers, a small flame, and time.

## THE WORKSHOPS

Tres Palacios · Villanueva · Pupo · Rocha · Herrera — all in the historic centre, all open to visitors by request. The Escuela Taller de Mompox (founded 1996) trains new maestros and welcomes observers.



BOCACHICO FRYING IN COCONUT OIL, ON A  
KITCHEN STOVE AT NOON

CHAPTER EIGHT

# Food

## VIII

*From the river, from the garden, from the slow-stirred pot. A note on what is eaten, and how.*

*"In Mompox, lunch is the meal. Everything else is a pause around it."*

— DOÑA ADA, OF THE DULCES DE LIMÓN

The food of Mompox is the food of the lower Magdalena: river fish, coconut, root vegetables, slow-cooked stews. It is not the food of the highlands — no ajiaco, no bandeja paisa — and it is not the food of the Caribbean coast, though it shares the coast's love of coconut rice. It is its own thing, quieter than either.

The fish is the centre. *Bocachico* — *Prochilodus magdalenae* — is the river's gift to the kitchen: a firm, white-fleshed fish, slightly oily, endemic to the Magdalena. It is fried whole, or stewed with coconut and coriander, or salted and dried in the sun for later. The bocachico is the river's gift to the kitchen — and most of it is eaten within a day's journey of where it is caught.

Alongside the fish you will be served *arroz con coco* — coconut rice, the coastal staple. In Mompox it is made the white way, with fresh coconut milk, not the brown way with caramelised *titoté*. There will be *patacón* — green plantain, flattened and fried twice. There will be *ensalada de repollo*, a sharp cabbage slaw to cut the richness. There will be *queso de capa*, the layered hand-stretched cheese, sometimes stuffed with bocadillo — guava paste — and fried.

The traditional soup is *mote de queso*: a coastal cheese and yam soup, thickened with the local cheese and seasoned with culantro and garlic. It is served at breakfast. It is one of the great unsung soups of Latin America.

For dessert, the *dulces de Mompox* — small, dense sweets made by hand, sold from the houses of the women who make them. Doña Ada's *dulce de limón* — a kind of candied lemon in syrup — is what people bring home from Mompox. There are also *cocadas* (coconut balls), *bocadillo con queso*, and in season, fresh fruit: mamey, zapote, níspero, guanábana, the fruits of the lower Magdalena valley that you will not easily find further north.

You do not come to Mompox for restaurants. You come for kitchens. The hotel table is a good one; the family kitchens of the town, if you are invited, are better. The market is the place to start. Walk through it at six in the morning. Look at the fish. Look at the fruit. You will understand the cuisine before you have eaten any of it.

In the bakery on Calle del Medio, the baker pulls pandebono from the oven at six. The smell crosses the street before the door is open.





## WHAT TO LOOK FOR, BY MONTH

### DECEMBER — MARCH · THE DRY SEASON

Bocachico at its best. Mamey, zapote, guanábana. The hour of the patio lunch — cold coconut rice, fried fish, slaw, a chilled beer.

### APRIL — JUNE · THE FIRST RAINS

The river begins to rise. Snail soup. Frog legs from the ciénagas. The mangoes ripen.

### JULY — SEPTEMBER · THE MID-YEAR BREAK

Fish is more variable; the river is high. Sweet corn. Fresh cheese. The festival of jazz in September.

### OCTOBER — NOVEMBER · THE WETTEST MONTHS

Some roads flood. The fish is salted and dried. The kitchens move indoors. Dulces de leche, made slowly, kept in tins.



A POUR-OVER AT THE HOTEL TERRACE, JUST AFTER  
SIX O'CLOCK

CHAPTER NINE

# Coffee

IX

*A single bean, from a small farm. A slow pour. A book on the terrace. The morning ritual.*

| *"A cup of coffee is a five-minute novel. You read it slowly. You do not skip to the end."*

The coffee served at Hotel Literatium comes from a single small finca in the Colombian coffee region. The beans are hand-picked, washed, and dried in the sun. The roast is medium. The grind is set the night before. The water is brought just off the boil. The pour is slow — three minutes for a single cup.

The Colombian coffee region — the Eje Cafetero — runs along the central cordillera, between one thousand and two thousand metres of altitude. The volcanic soil, the steady temperatures, the cloud cover in the afternoons, and the sharp drop in temperature at night all conspire to produce a bean of unusual density and complexity. The flavour profile, in the cup, tends toward citrus — orange, sometimes pink grapefruit — over caramel and milk chocolate, with a clean, bright acidity. It is the flavour of slowness.

The hotel serves this coffee in the morning, on the terrace, before the heat of the day. There is no menu of espresso drinks. There is no flavoured syrup. There is the bean, the water, the patience, and the cup. There is, if you like, a book from the hotel library — chosen the night before, left on the table by the chair you sat in at dinner. This is the morning ritual. It is, by design, the same every day.

Coffee in Colombia is not only a flavour. It is a literature. The great coffee-house of Colombian letters was the Autores Cafeteros, a Bogotá circle of the 1940s. García Márquez, a coastal writer who did not always love the highlands, nonetheless wrote his early journalism in cafés. The ritual of the tinto — the small, sweet, dark cup of the afternoon — is one of the country's uniting habits.

In Mompox the tinto is taken at four o'clock. It is poured from a small enamel pot into a small enamel cup. It is sweetened generously. It is not the pour-over of the morning terrace — it is another thing, smaller and darker, a punctuation mark in the heat of the afternoon. You drink it standing, in the doorway of a friend. Then you go back to what you were doing.

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*"The morning cup of coffee has the feeling of a small ceremony — repeated, deliberate, and never quite the same."*

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SMELL · TWO COFFEES

## *THE MORNING CUP, AND THE AFTERNOON TINTO*

### **MORNING · 5.30 TO 8.00**

The pour-over on the terrace. The bean is freshly ground. The first smell is caramel — the bean at the moment of contact with the water. Then, as it steeps, citrus. The cup, when it is poured, smells of toast and orange peel.

### **AFTERNOON · 4.00**

The tinto. Brewed long, kept warm. The smell is darker — molasses, almost burnt sugar, sometimes a hint of pipe tobacco. Sweetened in the cup. Drink it standing. It is the punctuation of the afternoon.



THE MARKET AT SIX, JUST AFTER THE FISH HAS  
ARRIVED FROM THE RIVER

## CHAPTER TEN

# Markets

X

*The market square before the heat. The order of fish, fruit, herbs. The order of the women who sell them.*

| *"A market is a town's daily newspaper, printed in fish and fruit."*

**T**he Mompox market opens at four-thirty in the morning. By six it is at full cry. By nine the heat has driven the sellers under the corrugated iron roofs, the fish has been sold, and the long slow afternoon of the market town has begun. If you sleep through the market, you have slept through Mompox.

The market sits on the edge of the historic centre, between the river road and the modern bridge. It is not picturesque. It is a working market. The fish comes from the river and the *ciénagas* — *bocachico*, *bagre*, *nicuro*, *capaz* — laid out on crushed ice in blue plastic crates. The fruit is seasonal: mango in May, mamey in the dry months, *guanábana* and *zapote* when the trees give them. The herbs are tied in bundles — *cilantro*, *culantro*, *guácimo*, the leaves that flavour the soups.

The women who sell are the order of the market. They arrive first. They arrange their stalls with a precision that would satisfy a museum curator. They greet each other by name, by the names of their children, by the names of their grandchildren. They have been doing this for thirty years. They will be doing it for thirty more. The men bring the produce and the fish; the women sell it. This is the arrangement.

Walk through slowly. Do not photograph without asking. Buy something — a mango, a piece of cheese, a bag of ice. Stand to one side and watch. The market is the place where Mompox is most itself — the place where the river and the garden and the kitchen meet, before the heat, before the tourists, before the day begins.



#### LOOK CLOSER · THE MARKET

### *FOUR THINGS TO NOTICE*

#### 01 THE HANDS OF THE FISH-SELLERS

Scarred from scales and fins. Quick. They can gut a *bocachico* in three cuts.

#### 02 THE STACKING OF FRUIT

A pyramid, not a heap. Each mango placed at the angle of the next. The architecture is informal but precise.

#### 03 THE SCALES

Brass, balanced, old. Some are a hundred years old. They click as the weights slide.

#### 04 THE HOURS

By nine the heat is too much. The sellers move to the shade. By ten the market is half-closed. By noon it is asleep. Return the next morning.





A PYRAMID OF MANGOES, MAY MORNING,  
THE PUBLIC MARKET





A GREAT EGRET ON THE BANK OF THE CIÉNAGA DE  
PIJIÑO, JUST AFTER SUNRISE

CHAPTER ELEVEN

# Wildlife

XI

*The river, the swamps, the walls. Howler monkeys, iguanas, egrets, and the migrants from the north.*

| *"In Mompox, the wild does not arrive. It is already here."*

Mompox sits inside the Magdalena wetland system, one of the most biodiverse freshwater ecosystems in the Americas. The river, the ciénagas, the gallery forest, the pasture — all support an abundance of life that is not always obvious from the malecón. You have to go out, by boat, early, to see it properly.

The mammals are the hardest to see but the most romantic. Colombian red howler monkeys — *Alouatta seniculus* — live in the gallery forest along the river. You will hear them before you see them: a low, guttural roar that carries for kilometres, at dawn and at dusk. The neotropical otter — *Lontra longicaudis* — is here, in the slower channels, though you will be lucky to see one. The lesser capybara — *Hydrochoerus isthmius* — is the Magdalena form of the world's largest rodent, and is common in the wetlands.

The reptiles are easier. The green iguana — *Iguana iguana* — is everywhere. You will see them on the walls of the churches, on the trunks of the royal palms, on the tiled roofs of the houses. They are harmless, slow, and prehistoric. The spectacled caiman — *Caiman crocodilus* — lives in the ciénagas; you will see them from the boat, eyes and snout above the water, at the edge of the reeds.

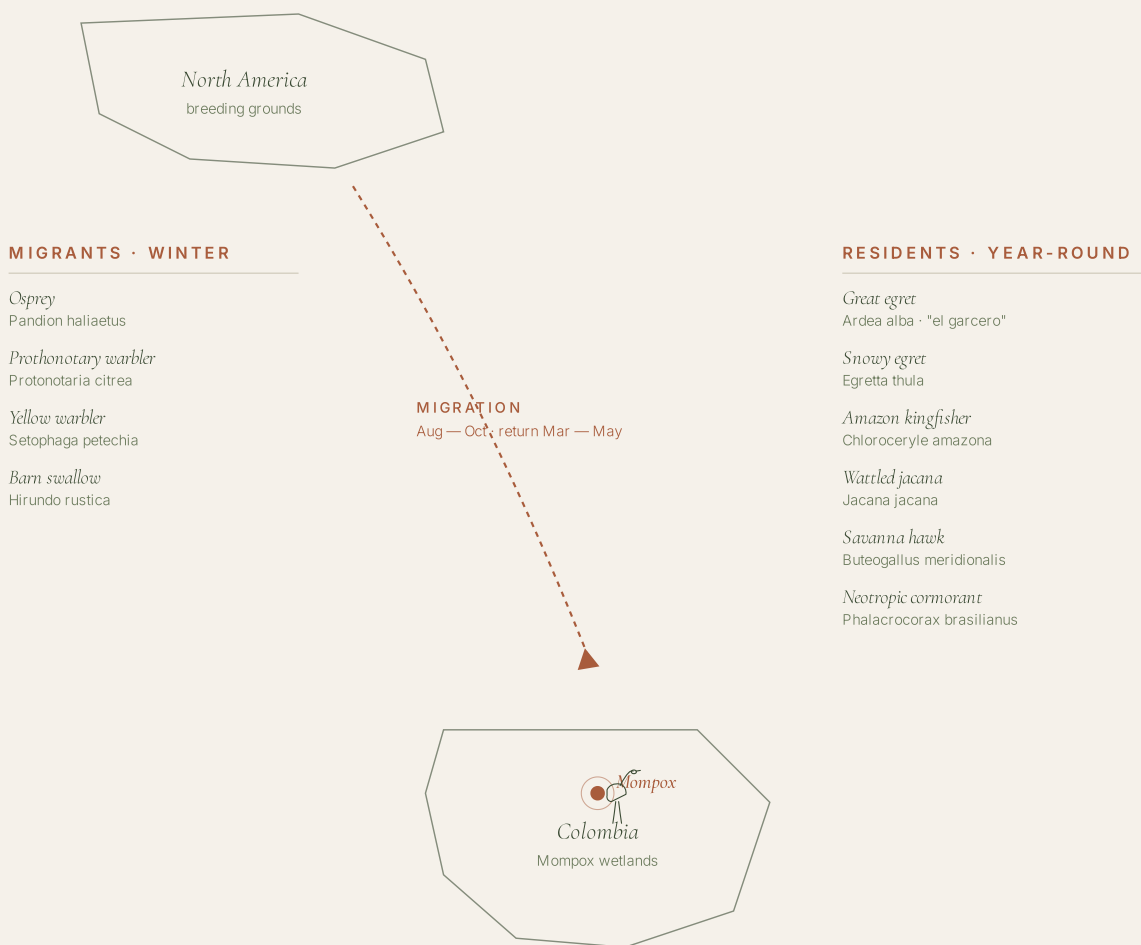
The birds are the point. The Magdalena valley is one of the great bird regions of the continent, and the Mompox wetlands are its quiet centrepiece. Resident herons — great egret, snowy egret, cocoi heron, little blue heron, striated heron — stand in the shallows. Kingfishers — Amazon, green, ringed — fly low along the channels. The wattled jacana walks on the lily pads. The savanna hawk sits on the fence posts. The neotropic cormorant dives and surfaces, dives and surfaces.

In the northern winter, the migrants arrive. Osprey from North America — *Pandion haliaetus* — fish the ciénagas from October to April. The prothonotary warbler — *Protonotaria citrea* — a small yellow bird of the eastern United States, winters here in extraordinary numbers; the Magdalena valley is one of its strongholds. To see a bird you might have seen in Louisiana, here, in a Mompox backyard, is to understand something about the world that no map can teach.



# From the north, to the river

*A small selection of the species that breed in North America and winter in the Mompox wetlands — and a few who live here year-round.*



The great egret — the white egret of the hotel's mark — is the symbol of the Magdalena wetlands.  
The best hours for birdwatching: 5.30–7.30 (dawn), and 4.30–6.00 (before sunset).

Species confirmed in the Mompox wetlands by Audubon, the Tropical Audubon Society, and verified trip reports from eBird. The prothonotary warbler, in particular, has its South American wintering stronghold here.



A WOODEN CANOE ENTERING THE CIÉNAGA DE  
PIJIÑO AT FIRST LIGHT

CHAPTER TWELVE

# Wetlands

## XII

*The ciénagas — the swamps of the lower Magdalena. The slow landscape behind the town.*

*"The river is the road. The ciénaga is the country."*

— DON EUSEBIO, BOATMAN OF PIJIÑO

**B**ehind Mompox, between the town and the river's true course, lies a network of wetlands — the *ciénagas*. The largest near the town is the *Ciénaga de Pijiño*. Further south, where the San Jorge meets the Magdalena, lies the great *Ciénaga de Zapatosa*, sixty kilometres long, the largest wetland in the Colombian Caribbean.

The *ciénagas* are not permanent. They breathe with the river. In the dry season — December to March — they shrink; the edges become pasture, the fish concentrate in the deeper channels, the wading birds gather in their thousands. In the wet season — April to November, with peaks in May and October — the river overtops its banks and the *ciénagas* fill. The forest beneath the water is drowned; the pasture beneath the water is forgotten. The landscape becomes a lake, and the lake is the colour of coffee.

The way to see the *ciénagas* is by boat. Hotel Literatium can arrange a launch — a wooden canoe with a small outboard — with one of the local fishermen, who will take you out at five in the morning to be on the water at first light. Bring binoculars. Bring a hat. Bring more water than you think you will need. The boat will move slowly through the channels between the reeds; the birds will not be frightened of you; the silence, broken only by the engine at low throttle, will be the deepest you have heard since you arrived.

You will see egret, heron, kingfisher. You may see howler monkey in the gallery forest. You may see caiman, if the water is low. You will certainly see fish — *bocachico* breaking the surface, tarpon rolling in the deeper pools. The boatman will point to things and name them. He has been doing this since he was a child. He knows every channel by the shape of the reeds.

Return by nine, before the heat. The rest of the day will be quieter for having seen it.



#### MARTICA RECOMMENDS · THE BOAT

### *A NOTE ON DON EUSEBIO*

Don Eusebio is the boatman we use. He is sixty-eight. He has been fishing the *Pijiño* since he was nine. He speaks no English, and only a little Spanish — his first language is the river. He charges by the hour; the rate is modest. He will not ask for more. If you wish to tip him, do so at the end, in cash, without ceremony. He has, in his life, pulled four people from the river who would otherwise have drowned. He does not mention this. The hotel will arrange the trip if you ask the evening before. The launch leaves the *malecón* at five.



A PHOTOGRAPHER AT THE CORNER OF CALLE REAL  
DEL MEDIO, BLUE HOUR

## CHAPTER THIRTEEN

# Photography

XIII

*Notes on the light, the rain, the moments worth stopping for. And on the moments worth putting the camera down.*

*"The camera, used well, is an instrument of attention. Used badly, it is a substitute for it."*

The light in Mompox is the reason photographers come. There are two hours you should plan your day around. The first is the golden hour — from six to seven in the morning, when the river mist is still on the water and the malecón is empty. The second is the blue hour — from six to seven in the evening, when the church towers go silhouetted against the sky and the street lights have not yet come on. Between these two hours, the light is hard and white, and best avoided.

The malecón at dawn is the first photograph. The river mist. The fishermen mending their nets. The egrets in the shallows. The donkey carts going home. Walk to the Ponte San Juan de Dios and look back at the town. The light comes from behind you. The whitewashed walls glow.

At the blue hour, walk to the Plaza de Santa Bárbara. The bell tower against the sky is the photograph every visitor tries to take. Most fail because they are too close. Stand back. Include the rooftops in the foreground. The tower belongs to the town; the town belongs to the tower. Wait for the moment the street light comes on, when the sky is still blue but the orange of the lamp is on the wall of the church.

Rain is a gift. In the wet season, afternoon storms come quickly and pass quickly. The streets flood for an hour. The reflections in the water are the photograph. Stand under an awning on Calle Real del Medio and wait. The light after the storm is the best light of the day.

For street portraits, ask. Mompox is not a place where people expect to be photographed, and the locals — especially the older women — may not wish it. Ask in Spanish, politely. *¿Puedo tomarle una foto?* If they say no, lower the camera, thank them, and walk on. If they say yes, show them the photograph afterward. This is the practice of respect.

Drones are restricted. The historic centre is a UNESCO site, and Colombian drone regulations require authorisation for flights over populated areas and near airports. The nearest airport is Las Brujas, in Sincelejo — close enough that the airspace rules apply. If you must fly, do so outside the historic centre, at low altitude, with explicit permission. Or, better, leave the drone in the bag and look up.

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*"Some places are best photographed with the camera in  
your pocket."*

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FIVE THINGS MOST VISITORS MISS

*FOR THE PHOTOGRAPHER*

*01* **THE MOSAIC FLOOR OF THE INMACULADA CONCEPCIÓN**

Photograph it from the choir loft, looking down. The pattern only resolves from above.

*02* **THE HANDS OF THE FILIGREE MAESTRO**

At work, with the wire and the tweezers. Ask permission first. Use natural light.

*03* **THE INSIDE OF A DOORWAY, LATE AFTERNOON**

When the door is ajar and the patio is visible inside. The contrast of street and interior is the contrast of Mompox itself.

*04* **THE REFLECTIONS AFTER RAIN**

The cobblestones flood. The town doubles itself in the water. Walk to the lowest part of Calle Real del Medio and wait for the rain to stop.

*05* **THE CATS OF THE CEMETERY**

At the hour of the long shadows. They are tame, but do not touch. Photograph them on the headstones, where they belong.



A MORNING STREET, CALLE REAL DEL MEDIO,  
BEFORE THE DAY BEGINS

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

# Forty-Eight Hours

XIV

*A two-day slow itinerary, written as a sequence of moments rather than a checklist.  
Adjust, abandon, ignore.*

| *"The itinerary is a suggestion. The journey is the thing."*

What follows is not a schedule. It is a shape — a sequence of hours, in the order in which they might unfold. Take what is useful. Leave what is not. The point is to be in Mompox, not to have completed Mompox.

DAY ONE

*THE RIVER, THE CHURCHES,  
THE WORKSHOP*

5.30 Coffee on the terrace. The river mist is on the water. A book, if you like.

6.30 Walk the malecón. A fisherman mends his net with a wooden needle. He nods.

8.00 Breakfast — fruit, eggs, arepa, more coffee. On the terrace, in the shade.

9.00 The market, before the heat. A woman selling mangoes puts one in your hand without asking.

10.30 The Inmaculada Concepción. The silver tabernacle. The mosaic floor, from the choir loft.

12.00 Lunch. Bocachico, fried, with coconut rice and slaw. A cold beer. The patio of the hotel.

2.00 The reading hour. A chair. A book. The shade of the mango tree.

4.00 The Taller Escuela de Filigrilla. The maestro does not look up. He is drawing wire. Stay an hour.

6.00 Santa Bárbara. The bells ring three times. The light catches the tower. Stay until they stop.

8.00 Dinner at the hotel table. A glass of wine. The terrace, again.

9.30 Café Ti, if there is music. One drink. Then sleep. The boat leaves at five tomorrow.

## DAY TWO

# *THE RIVER, AGAIN, BY BOAT*

5.00 The malecón. Don Eusebio is waiting. The launch moves out into the ciénaga in the dark.

6.00 First light on the water. Egret, heron, kingfisher. The silence, broken only by the engine at low throttle.

9.00 Return. Breakfast on the terrace. You will be tired, and quiet, and the morning will taste different.

10.30 The cemetery. Avenues of palm. A cat sleeps on a name. The mausoleums of the old families.

12.30 Lunch — a simpler thing today. Mote de queso. Arepa. Coffee.

2.00 The reading hour, again. Choose a different chair. Choose a different book.

4.00 Calle de Atrás, slowly. A doorway opens. A doorway closes. Stop at the Piedra de Bolívar.

6.00 The malecón, for the last evening. The whole town is out. The river is the colour of the sky.

8.00 Dinner. The hotel table. A glass of something. The terrace.

# Six stops, half a day, on foot

*A schematic of the Mompox historic centre — the river, the three streets, the three plazas, and the places to pause.*



Stops: (1) Hotel Literatium · (2) Inmaculada Concepción — the silver tabernacle · (3) The malecón — the riverfront promenade · (4) The Taller Escuela de Filigrilla — the filigree workshop · (5) Santa Bárbara — the baroque tower · (6) Cementerio Central — the cemetery of palms and cats. Total walking time, with stops, half a day.



A PACKED BAG AT THE HOTEL DOOR, THE MORNING  
OF DEPARTURE

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

# Practical Guide

XV

*The plain things, in plain language. Money, weather, transport, health, what to bring, what to say.*

| *"The romance of a place is built on its plumbing."*

**M**ompox is in the Colombian tropics, at low altitude, on a river. It is hot. It is, in the wet season, wet. The infrastructure is limited but adequate. The following is what you need to know — beyond what is in the rest of this book.

The receptionist at the hotel desk has a list of phone numbers in a small blue notebook. She will lend it to you, copy a page for you, call a doctor for you. She has done this before.

## MONEY

### Colombian Peso · COP

Approximately 3,350 COP to 1 USD (mid-2026). Bring some cash — Mompox has few ATMs and the one in the central plaza is not always working. Most hotels and the better restaurants accept cards; market stalls and small shops do not. Tip in cash, modestly, only for good service.

## WEATHER

### Hot, and wet in season

Average daytime temperatures 28–30°C, with peaks above 33°C in the dry season. Dry season: December to March, with peaks in February and March. Wet season: April to November, with the heaviest rain in May and October. The last thirty kilometres of road can flood in October; check before you travel.

## EMERGENCIES

### 123 — national number

Colombia uses a single national emergency number — 123 — for police, medical, and fire. The hotel reception will help with any emergency and can arrange a doctor or a pharmacy run. The local hospital, San Juan de Dios, has been in operation since 1550; routine care is available there.

## TRANSPORT

### By road, by river

Direct Unitransco buses run from Cartagena (about six hours, twice daily, around USD 25). The classic alternative is bus to Magangué, then a chalupa (small boat) across the river to Bodega, then a colectivo on to Mompox — longer but more interesting. There is no airport. The closest is Las Brujas, in Sincelejo, three hours by road.

## HEALTH

### Vaccinations · water

Yellow fever vaccination is recommended for the lower Magdalena — consult your travel clinic. Mosquito-borne diseases (dengue, chikungunya) are present; bring repellent and wear long sleeves at dawn and dusk. Drink bottled or filtered water. The hotel provides filtered water in the rooms.

## PACKING

### Light, breathable, modest

Light cotton or linen. Long sleeves for the evening mosquitoes. A hat for the sun. A light rain jacket in the wet season. Comfortable walking shoes with grip — the cobblestones are uneven and slippery after rain. Binoculars if you are birding. A book. A notebook. A second book.



## Claro for coverage

Claro has the best coverage in Mompox; Movistar and Tigo also work. SIM cards are sold at the airport and at any Claro shop in Cartagena; bring your passport. eSIM is available for newer phones. The hotel has WiFi, though it is slower than you may be used to. This is, depending on your point of view, a feature.

## RESPONSIBLE TRAVEL

### Slow, local, respectful

Buy filigree directly from the workshops, not from resellers. Tip the boatmen in cash. Ask before photographing people, especially in churches and at the market. Drones are restricted over the historic centre — leave it in the bag. Take your plastic with you; recycling infrastructure in Mompox is limited. Be quiet in the churches, even if no service is on.

## USEFUL SPANISH · A SMALL PHRASEBOOK

|                             |                        |
|-----------------------------|------------------------|
| <i>Buenos días</i>          | Good morning           |
| <i>Buenas tardes</i>        | Good afternoon         |
| <i>Buenas noches</i>        | Good evening / night   |
| <i>Por favor</i>            | Please                 |
| <i>Gracias</i>              | Thank you              |
| <i>Con permiso</i>          | Excuse me / pardon     |
| <i>¿Cuánto cuesta?</i>      | How much does it cost? |
| <i>La cuenta, por favor</i> | The bill, please       |
| <i>¿Dónde está...?</i>      | Where is...?           |

## 110V · 60 Hz · Type A/B

Colombia uses 110V at 60 Hz, with Type A and Type B plugs (the same as North America). European and UK devices need an adapter. The hotel rooms have two-pin sockets; the desk in the library has a Type B three-pin. Charging is reliable.

## FESTIVALS

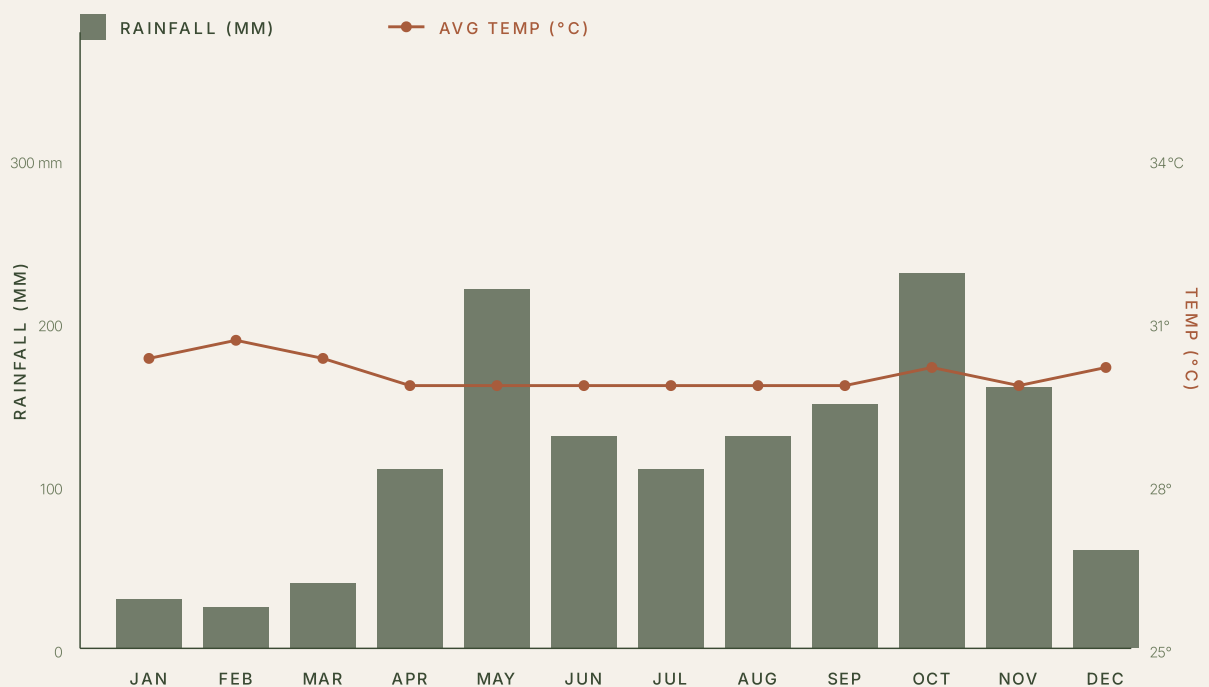
### Two worth planning around

Semana Santa (Holy Week) — processions every evening, the famous "two steps forward, one back" march, the *Serenata a los Difuntos* at the cemetery. The Festival Internacional de Jazz de Mompox — held each September, free, in the open air; the eleventh edition is in September 2025. Both fill the town; book well in advance.

|                                 |                        |
|---------------------------------|------------------------|
| <i>No entiendo</i>              | I don't understand     |
| <i>¿Habla inglés?</i>           | Do you speak English?  |
| <i>Un café, por favor</i>       | A coffee, please       |
| <i>¿Puedo tomarle una foto?</i> | May I take your photo? |
| <i>Estoy perdido</i>            | I am lost              |
| <i>Necesito un médico</i>       | I need a doctor        |
| <i>Ayuda</i>                    | Help                   |
| <i>¿A qué hora...?</i>          | At what time...?       |
| <i>Mañana</i>                   | Tomorrow               |

# A year on the river

Average rainfall and temperature by month. The wet season is bimodal — two peaks, in May and October.



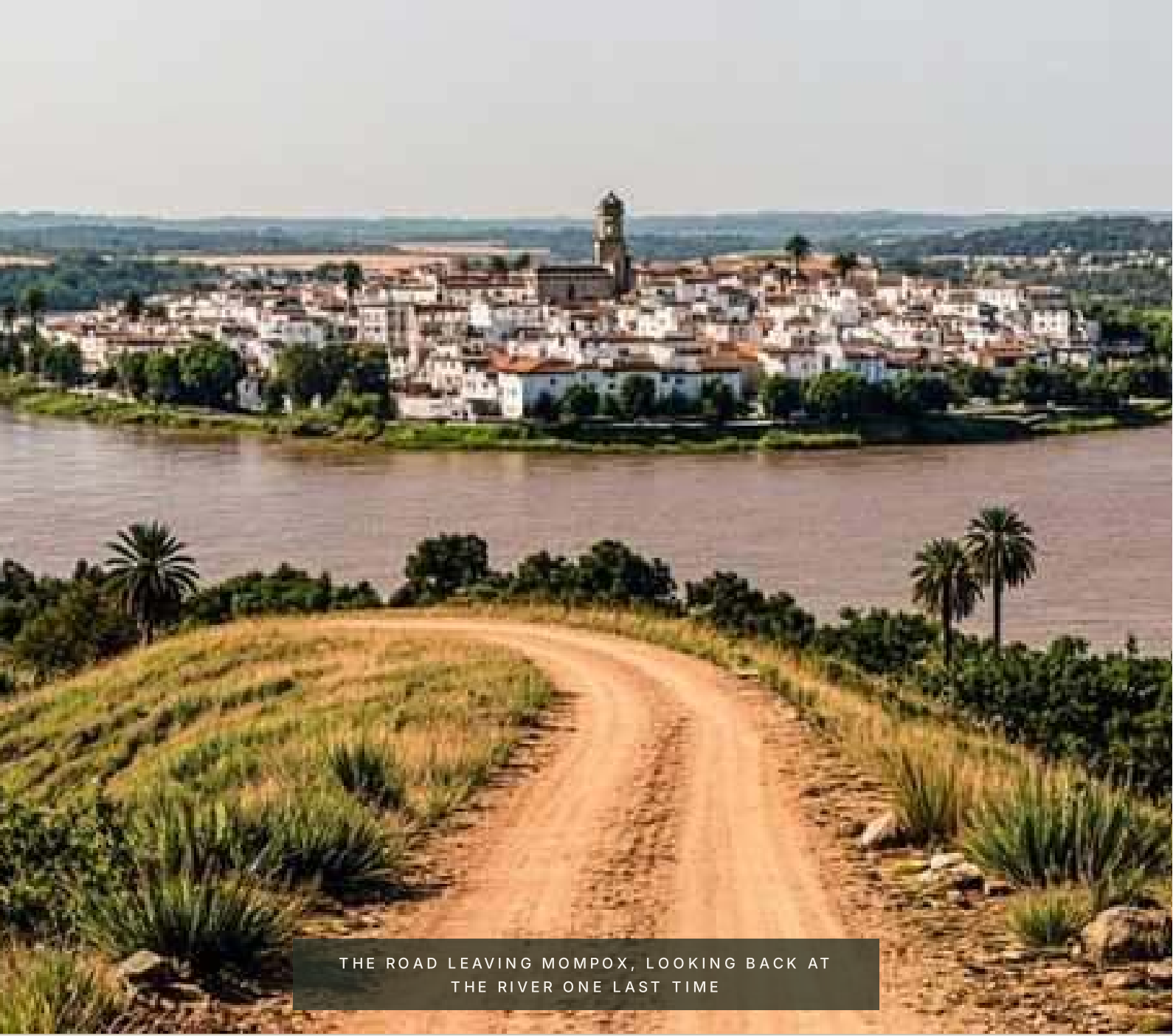
*Dry season*

*First wet peak — May*

*Second wet peak — October*

Best months to visit: December to March (dry, hot, clear river). May and October: dramatic skies, fewer visitors, some road flooding.

Climate data approximated from IDEAM Colombia averages for the Mompox region. Actual rainfall varies year to year; the bimodal pattern — two peaks, two dry shoulders — is consistent.



THE ROAD LEAVING MOMPOX, LOOKING BACK AT  
THE RIVER ONE LAST TIME

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

# Departure

XVI

*A note on leaving. The slow farewell. The book you take with you.*

*"You do not leave a place like this. You carry it out, slowly, in your hands."*

— FROM THE HOTEL GUEST BOOK

The morning of departure, you will wake earlier than you need to. The courtyard will be quiet. The coffee will already be on the table on the terrace — the maestro has anticipated you. There will be an hour, after breakfast and before the bus, in which you will not know what to do with yourself. This is the hour Mompox gives you, on the way out, as a parting gift.

Walk the malecón one last time. The river will be the same colour it was the morning you arrived. The egrets will be in the same shallows. The fishermen will be mending the same nets. Nothing will have changed, except that you have changed, and that is the only change that matters.

Pack slowly. The bag will be heavier than when you came — a book from the hotel library, a small piece of filigree wrapped in tissue, a bottle of dulce de limón from Doña Ada. You will lose the way of seeing, gradually, in the weeks after you return. The point is to have had it.

The bus leaves from the stand at the edge of the historic centre. It crosses the bridge. It climbs the low ridge to the south. From the ridge, there is one last view of the town — whitewashed, low, beneath its palms, between the river and the sky. The bus does not stop. You will not be able to photograph it. You will remember it.

Then the road turns inland, the river disappears, and you are on the way back to the world that has the rest of your life in it. The book on your lap. The taste of coffee still in your mouth. The river, somewhere behind you, still going slowly to the sea.

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*"Some places you visit. Some places visit you, for a long  
time afterward, in the quiet hours."*

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A MORNING STREET, BEFORE THE DAY BEGINS —  
AGAIN

CLOSING

# If You Come Back

*A note for the returning visitor. What changes, what doesn't.*



**Y**ou will come back. Most people do.

When you do, the town will be the same and not the same. The malecón will still be there. The egrets will still stand in the shallows. The church bells will still ring at six. But you will notice things you missed the first time — a doorway, a cornice, a particular tree — because the first visit is always an introduction, and the second is a conversation.

Walk after rain. The cobblestones flood for an hour. The reflections are the photograph you did not take last time. The light after the storm is the best light of the day.

Read in the courtyard. Choose a different chair. Choose a different book. The shade of the mango tree moves through the afternoon, and the chair that was in sun at two is in shade at four. This is information you did not have before.

Return in another season. The dry season is easier. The wet season is greener. The river is higher. The ciénaga is fuller. The birds are different. Mompox in October is not Mompox in February. It is worth seeing both.

Learn a few more Spanish words. The ones you learned last time got you through the market. A few more will get you through a conversation. The waiter at the hotel will help. The boatman will not, but he will smile.

Watch sunrise twice. Once from the malecón. Once from the boat. They are not the same sunrise.

Stay one day longer than you planned.





## HOTEL LITERATIUM

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Bolívar · Colombia

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*La Casa de las Historias*

